

Buzz on Android

Google has launched the Buzz widget for Android mobile phone users



Energy Clock

Tendrill Vision is a device which connects to the grid to give you a real time information about your energy use and cost

three phones are of poor quality as they tend to bend when you open the phone. In V1405, the battery slot is somewhat constricted which makes it difficult to detach the battery if you want to replace it.

Intex IN4420 has an extendable antenna which allows FM Radio to be played without the need for earphones. Intex IN4410 has a rear flap which can only be opened with the help of some sharp object, which is very annoying. Its keypad is quite good as compared to that of IN4420 but not as good as IN4477.

g-Fone 565 has a very compartmentalised design. The numberpad, navigation pad and the four buttons surrounding it are isolated from each other. It also has a speaker on the rear side which is quite loud.

All phones in this category have multimedia features like an audio player, FM Radio and video player. Only Videocon 'V1306 has no video option. The user interface of all the phones is somewhat similar as is the underlying operating system.

Performance

Intex IN4477 had the best call strength and quality in both the test zones. g-Fone 565 and

Intex IN4410 gave a poor call quality in zone 2. The rest of the phones in this category performed almost the same in both the zones. None of the calls were dropped in zone two despite it being in the basement where there is a high chance of that happening.

Intex IN4420 and fly B430 had a great Bluetooth data transfer speed of 128 Kbps whereas the Videocon V1405 gave a measly 17 Kbps. The other two ie. V1306 and V1402 did not have Bluetooth. IN4477 gave a speed of 50Kbps which was next best.



Fly B430

The camera quality and video output of IN4477 was quite poor. g-Fone had good image quality. On the whole, the camera and video playback in this segment was not really great. Many phones like V1405, V1402 have a very slow refresh rate for video recording which results in poor quality halting videos. The Fly B430 has the best speaker in this segment.

Olive V-G200 has a massive 2,000 mAh battery which gives a whopping 12 hours of talktime according to the manufacturer. But its touch response leaves a lot to be desired.

HOW WE TESTED

We got around 30 cellphones to test. Since this is an entry level cellphone test, we kept the upper limit price at Rs.8,000. Based on the pricing we divided the test into four categories..

Cellphones are instruments that are feature-based and when a purchase is being made, you only have enough time to have a quick run through of its features. Apart from cellphones being a communication tool, its also an accessory. Keeping this in mind, we gave equal weightage to the features of the cellphone like its form factor, ergonomics, keypad, user interface, additional tools like camera, speakers, FM among other things. Dual SIM capability was judged as a feature since 18 phones had that facility.

For testing the voice quality, we identified two Zones namely Zone 1 and Zone 2. In Zone 1 the signal

strength and voice quality were studied for a call that was made from same floor. Whereas for Zone 2 we took the cellphone in our building's basement where there are high chances of call-dropping. The cellphones inbuilt receiver and speaker quality were checked in Zone 1.

The camera quality was judged after clicking an indoor and an outdoor photograph. The same was done with the video. Image and video quality were kept at the highest resolution supported by that camera phone. Other settings like AWB, Effects and Exposure were kept at default for all the phones. The photographs were transferred from the microSD card to a PC and checked for crispness and colour clarity. Videos that were recorded were played on media player classic to check for their quality.

More for less (Rs. 4,201 to Rs. 6,000)

This category had around eight phones. Here we looked at phones which had additional features like better cameras and audio/video.

Features

This segment had a lot of variety in terms of form factor, keypads and interface. ZTE GN281 and Fly E106 were the two full touchscreen phones. E106 has an excellent design along with a 2.0 MP camera. It comes with a stylus and has dedicated buttons on the side for locking the phone and camera shutter. ZTE GN281 at 2.8 inches had the largest screen and it comes in a radical baby-pink colour that made it stand out.

Samsung B2100 had the best build amongst all the phones that we tested. It has been advertised as a waterproof phone that can work even

when submerged (we didn't test this however). We did pour some water on the rear side and on opening the flap, found the battery to be absolutely dry. The phone has an rubberised body which gives a very good grip.

G-fone 588 has a full QWERTY keypad with a good overall build. It comes with a 1.3 MP camera and has nicely raised buttons which allow fast typing. Videocon V1602 has some good features like isolated keys and a nice wide screen.

Nokia 2700 is aesthetically very pleasing. With a black plastic curved rear end and a front end with a glossy finish

Nokia 2700 has a simple design. The phone has as many as five languages to choose from namely English, Hindi, Marathi and Gujarati. Apart from the regular menus, it has two additional menus called Life Tools and Maps. Nokia 3110 on the other hand has a smaller 1.3MP camera, but it has a good audio player along with FM Radio facility. The



Samsung B2100

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